compelled to come to divided Berlin, and, in turn, the city became a productive space for confronting and testing the limits of freedom and their American identities. However, whereas Freed and Davis were prompted to return to the United States for their creative and critical productions, Tajiri's divided Berlin project would remain in exile, as a closely held reflection on themes, places, and modes of representing the Wall and its cultural analogues. While traversing the city, Tajiri shifted and honed his previous methodological approaches to deal with the context of the Wall's reconstruction. Many of his other artworks differed in recognizability and levels of abstraction but shared in his approaches to mine personal or historical experiences through the symbolism of material traces. He outlined his working ethos: "The student, the artist, has to discover some sort of individual expression. I always have this idea that the artist or the student has to be a kind of an archaeologist and he has to pick as if to reign himself, and out of himself he has to produce these artifacts which tells me and tells themselves who they are. It's all a process of selfrealization [*sic*], and i think that's something you can't teach but you have to sort of encourage and guide."[32]

Tajiri worked out themes of excessive militarism, technology, and aggression—historically found within nuanced artworks pertaining to his home country's history and the Cold War between the United States and the USSR. Though he relocated to Europe, he kept a U.S. passport throughout his life, to ensure his ability to heal hinged on his desire to speak out against the violence and dislocation that haunted his youth and continued into his adulthood.

Tajiri's sculptural and conceptual works often reframed American national mythology and symbolism around dialectical pairings of spatial presence and absence. He cited American sculptor Gutzon Borglum as one of the few artists who influenced his practice, because Borglum "blasted the heads of 4 presidents out of the granite slopes of mount rushmore [*sic*]." (Borglum also contributed to Confederate Stone Mountain outside Atlanta, Georgia, and *Wars of America* in Military Park in Newark, New Jersey.) Tajiri understood the parallels between calculated destruction and Borglum's notion of "emotional value of volume" to use new methods to fathom monumental projects about American history, regardless of size or scope.[33] He viewed American geopolitics and constructed artworks by proposing